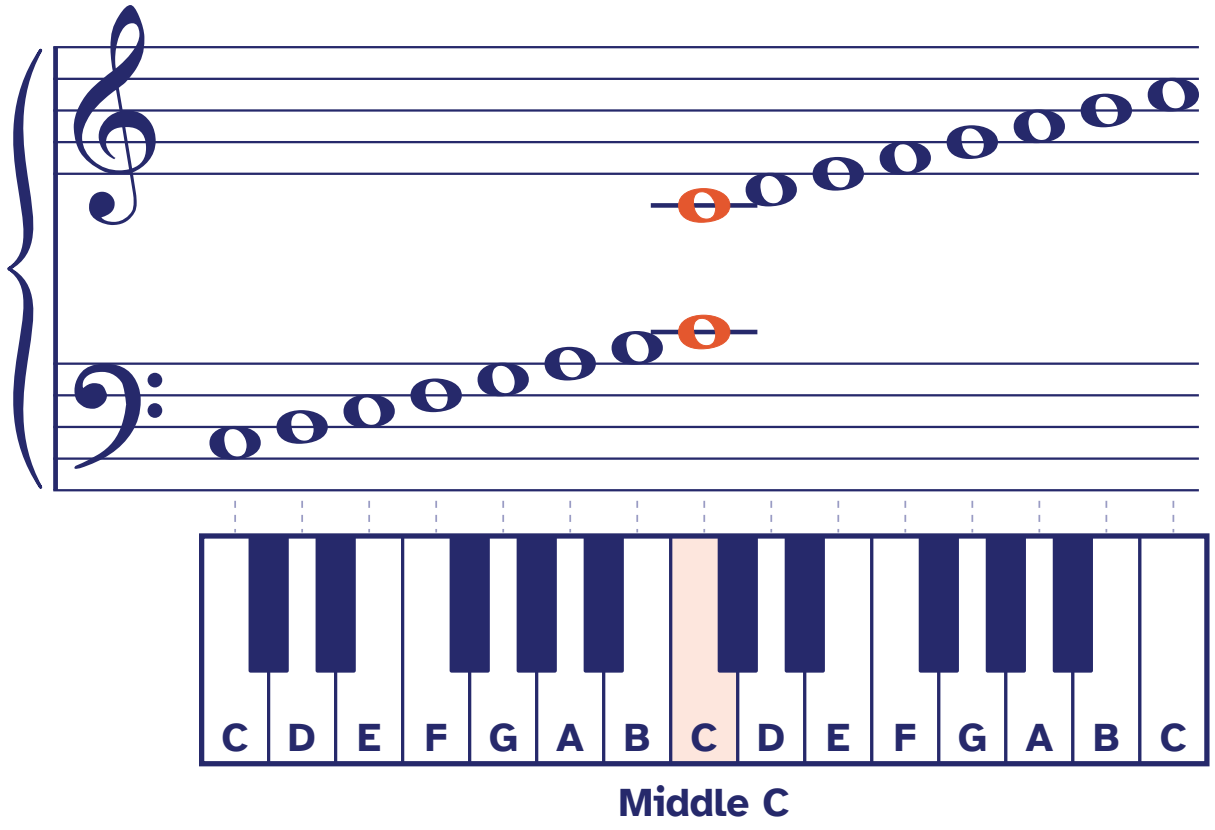
PART I · PITCH · 3

The staff and the keyboard

Each line and each space of the grand staff is one white key. Climb the staff and you climb the keyboard: here are two octaves, from Bass C to Treble C, with Middle C in red where the two staves meet.

THE SECRET

Every line and every space is one white key, in order.



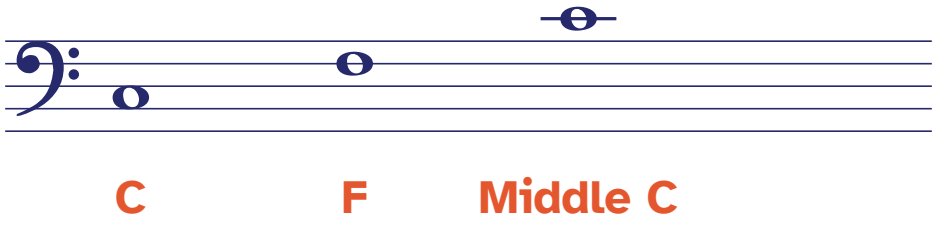
Between the two staves there is only one key: **Middle C**, written twice, below the treble staff or above the bass staff. No other key is missed out.

One step on the staff, line to space or space to line, is the very next **white** key (the black keys come in chapter 6, p. 39). Up the staff is to the **right** on the keyboard; down the staff is to the **left**. A note on a line and the note in the space just above it are next-door white keys, so no key is ever missed out.

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

From the page to the key

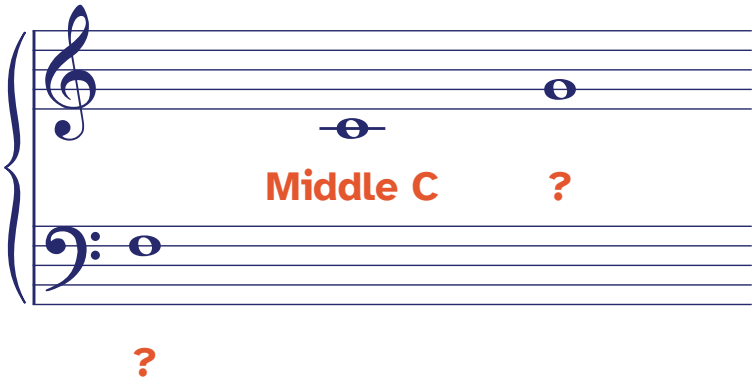


1. **Name the note:** line 4 of the bass staff, between the clef's dots, is F.
2. **On the piano,** find the three black keys just below Middle C.
3. **F is the first key** of that family: play it with the left hand.

The bass-clef F is the **F just below Middle C**: left of the three black keys under it.

EXAMPLE 2

Mirror notes either side of Middle C



1. **Treble G:** the three black keys just above Middle C; G is the second key, after F.
2. **Bass F:** the three black keys just below Middle C; F is the first key.
3. **Now count each from Middle C:** C D E F G up, C B A G F down. Which number?

Both are **note 5**: mirror images. Fold the grand staff at Middle C and treble G lands exactly on bass F; the staves meet line for line.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



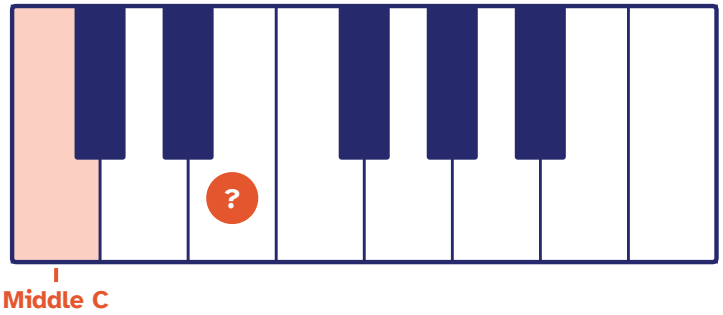
Play Middle C, then walk up.

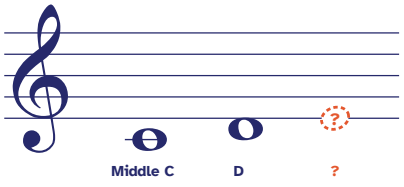
Say each white key as you play it, C D E F G A B C, and picture each one climbing the staff: line, space, line, space.

PART I · PITCH · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

From the key to the page



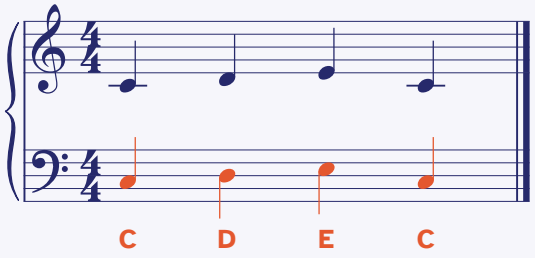


1. **Find the ? key:** count up from Middle C, C 1, D 2 …
2. **Do the same on the staff:** Middle C on its ledger line, D in the space under the staff …
3. **Where do you land?**

The **?** is **E**, note 3, and it sits on the **bottom line** of the treble staff.

YOU KNOW THIS

Frère Jacques, in both hands



The left hand plays the **same letters**, C D E C, one octave lower, written in the bass clef.

Try it. Play it right hand, then left hand, then both together.

THINK OF IT The staff is a ladder laid beside the keyboard: each rung, a line or a space, is the next white key.

TRAP

- × Skipping a key: every line and every space is used, one white key each.
- × Counting from 0: the note you start on is note 1.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 27 · Reading the notes p. 32

PRACTISE IT

Workbook pp. 5–6 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs · Line and Space Names